HARBOURLIGHT MEDIA

Clearance Guide: Price and Offer Claims

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1. What this guide covers

This guide covers claims about a product's price and offers such as savings, multibuys, boosted odds, free bets and cashback. It is used by the Clearance Executive who reviews the copy, from the first read until the issue is settled, and by Agency Liaisons advising agencies before they submit.

It arises most often in less healthy food, betting and gaming and alcohol copy, and in any category that runs a promotion.

A gift, a voucher or cashback offered with a credit product is a price or offer claim, but any figure about what credit costs - an APR, a repayment, or a 0% or interest-free period - is a financial promotion, and the Financial Promotions guide covers it. A betting offer pushed with urgency is a gambling inducement, and the Gambling Inducements guide covers it.

Whether a campaign's spots may be transmitted is a separate question, settled by the category's own code. This guide is about the copy.

2. How it usually shows up

- a headline saving: half price, two for one, a meal deal, a was and now price
- boosted odds, a price boost, a free bet or a welcome package in betting copy
- offer terms missing, in small print below the price, or on screen too briefly to read
- a price in the voiceover that differs from the price in the super
- a promotion that may end before the campaign's last booked spot

3. What the executive checks

For a price or an offer, the Clearance Executive checks, in this order:

1. List every price, saving and offer in the copy, and where each appears: voiceover, super or end frame.
2. Check each offer's significant conditions sit with its headline and stay on screen long enough to read.
3. Ask for the pricing history behind any saving, to show it is genuine against the usual price.
4. Check the promotion runs for the whole booking, so that no spot advertises an offer that has ended.
5. For betting, check the minimum stake, the eligible markets and any wagering requirement are shown with the offer.

4. Evidence to ask for

- the full promotion terms
- the pricing history for any saving or any was and now price
- confirmation that the promotion runs for every booked spot
- for betting, the wagering terms and the eligible markets

5. When the copy can be cleared

The copy can be cleared once each saving is shown to be genuine, every offer's significant conditions are legible beside its headline, and the voiceover and the supers agree. The usual amendment is to enlarge the terms and hold them for longer on the end frame, or to add the qualifying conditions beneath the headline.

6. What the agency should do

Before submitting, and when answering a query, the agency should:

- Put the significant conditions beside the headline, not only in the small print.
- Hold the terms on screen long enough to be read, at a size that can be read.
- Keep the price in the voiceover and the price in the supers the same.
- Send the pricing history and the full terms with the copy.

7. When to ask for a legal review

Ask for a legal review when an offer's conditions are complex, when a saving depends on a comparison with another price, or when a betting offer carries a wagering requirement.

The Legal Adviser records the review on the campaign, and its view carries more weight than any other note.

8. Recording the outcome

The outcome is recorded in an update on the campaign: the copy amended, the evidence accepted, or the copy cleared as submitted.

The assessment then recommends one of the decisions open for the campaign, and a Clearance Controller decides, as the Advertising Clearance Policy describes. Copy that cannot be cleared is rejected, whatever its spots' results.